Inspecting Parts from Ten Good Photographs on a Laptop CPU: Frozen CLIP Features, an Append-Only Memory, and What It Costs

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Abstract

We ask whether a small manufacturer can start automated visual inspection with nothing more than a few photographs of good parts and the laptop it already has. Our detector keeps a frozen OpenCLIP image encoder, stores the patch features of 1–10 normal photos in a separate memory for each product, and flags test patches that resemble none of them; it trains nothing. We evaluate it on four datasets (MVTec AD, VisA, NEU-DET, MPDD) with up to three backbones in FP32 and INT8, three random draws of the support photos, and paired statistics, and we time every configuration on one consumer CPU. With ten photos and the last transformer block, ViT-B/16 reaches 0.904 image AUROC on MVTec AD. Taking patch tokens from blocks 6, 9 and 12 as well raises this to 0.938, and to 0.945 with windowed scoring, for under 10% more CPU time; the gain is similar on VisA and absent on NEU-DET and MPDD. With these features our detection is better than that of PatchCore given the same photos on MVTec AD, VisA and MPDD, and localisation is level on MVTec AD. On WinCLIP's protocol we finish 2–4 points below its published few-shot results while running the encoder once per image. Two practical findings stand out. First, the cheapest backbone is enough exactly when defects cover more of the image than one of its patches, which held on the three datasets where we compared backbones. Second, the laptop slows five- to six-fold after a few minutes of continuous use, so burst latency overstates throughput. Adding a product left every other product's scores bit-identical in all our checks, and inspecting 10,000 parts a day costs tens of rupees of electricity a year.

1 Introduction

Visual inspection in a small workshop usually means a person looking at each part. Automating it runs into three practical problems before accuracy even matters. When a line is new there are many good parts and almost no examples of failures, so a method that learns from defects has nothing to learn from. The only computer is often an office laptop, and nobody on site trains neural networks. And the product mix changes: when a new part is introduced, inspection of the existing parts must not be disturbed.

Anomaly detection trained on normal images addresses the first problem, and on the MVTec AD benchmark [2] memory-based methods such as PatchCore [9] are close to perfect. They are normally fitted on hundreds of images per product, though, and their reported results are accuracies. Vision–language models reduced the number of images to a handful [6], but they were evaluated on GPUs. We could not find a study that says how such a system behaves on a laptop CPU, what it costs to run, or what happens to the products already being inspected when a new one is added.

This paper is that study. We use a deliberately plain detector: a frozen CLIP encoder [8, 4] and a nearest-neighbour memory of good patches, with two optional refinements, scoring over small windows of patches and fusing a text prompt into the image score. We measure four things:

1. accuracy as a function of the number of good photos (1, 5, 10), on four datasets that differ in defect size and domain;
2. which backbone and precision a workshop should choose, and why;
3. the CPU cost, both for a cool machine and under continuous use;
4. whether adding a product leaves the others untouched.

We compare against PatchCore given the same photos and against WinCLIP on its own protocol, and we release the code, the split files and a command for every table.

2 Related work

Learning from normal images. MVTec AD [2] and VisA [13] established the protocol of fitting on defect-free images and testing on both kinds. PaDiM [5] models each patch position with a Gaussian over pretrained CNN features; PatchCore [9] stores a coreset of patch features and scores a test patch by its distance to the nearest stored one. Our memory uses the same nearest-neighbour rule but keeps every support patch, because a ten-photo memory is already small, and it keeps a separate memory per

product. We use anomalib's [1] implementation of PatchCore as our baseline.

Vision–language models. CLIP [8] embeds images and text in one space, so an image can be scored against prompts such as "a photo of a damaged bottle" without any examples. WinCLIP [6] adds features computed on image windows and, with a few normal images, a reference memory (WinCLIP+). AnomalyCLIP [12] instead learns prompts that do not depend on the object. Both papers report GPU results only. We take two ideas from WinCLIP, windows and fusing text with the memory, but compute the windows from one encoder pass. APRIL-GAN [3] combines patch tokens from several depths of the encoder and trains linear layers on top of them; we take tokens from several depths as well but train nothing.

Adapting CLIP without training. Tip-Adapter [11] turns the support features into a key–value cache for few-shot classification. We tried its kernel as an anomaly head. At its best setting it gave exactly the nearest-neighbour ranking, which follows from the kernel being monotonic in cosine similarity while AUROC depends only on ranks, so we do not use it.

3 Method

Patch features. Each image is resized to 224×224 and passed through a frozen OpenCLIP ViT with OpenAI weights. The transformer's patch tokens (768 dimensions for B/32 and B/16, 1024 for L/14) are used as they are, before CLIP's projection to 512 dimensions; on MVTec AD the unprojected tokens scored 0.020–0.026 higher image AUROC (3.7–4.4 times the paired standard error). B/32 gives a 7×7 grid of patches, B/16 14×14 and L/14 16×16.

Multi-layer features. The last block of a CLIP ViT is trained to summarise the whole image, which blurs where things are. Earlier blocks keep more local detail. For ViT-B/16 we therefore also take the tokens of blocks 6 and 9, apply the final layer norm to each block's tokens, normalise them, and concatenate the three. The cosine between two such vectors is the mean of the three per-block cosines. We fixed the blocks before running the experiment: half, three-quarter and full depth, three of the four depths APRIL-GAN takes from ViT-L/14. A memory then needs 2,304 numbers per patch instead of 768, about 18 MB per product with ten photos.

Memory and scores. Adding a product stores the normalised patch vectors of its k good photos in a memory used only by that product. A test patch q scores

$$s(q) = 1 - \max_{m} \cos(q, m), \tag{1}$$

the maximum running over the product's stored patches. The image score is the largest patch score; the patch scores, bilinearly upsampled and smoothed with a Gaussian ($\sigma = 4$), form the anomaly map. Since products share no state, adding one cannot change another's scores, and Section 5.1 checks this directly.

Windows and text. Optionally the patch vectors are average-pooled over 2×2 and 3×3 windows and each window is scored against equally pooled support windows; the three maps are spread back to patch resolution and averaged. Optionally the image score becomes $0.5\, s_{\text{memory}} + 0.5\, s_{\text{text}}$, where s_{text} is the softmax weight that CLIP's pooled image embedding gives to a prompt ensemble for a defective object (plus a description typed by the user) against one for a normal object. The weight 0.5 follows WinCLIP+; we report the full range from 0 to 1.

Threshold and deployment. The application suggests a threshold by scoring each good photo against the others and taking the largest score. The encoder can be exported to ONNX (identical outputs to PyTorch on 50 real test images) and quantised dynamically to INT8, which needs no calibration images.

4 Experimental setup

Data. MVTec AD (15 products, pixel masks), VisA (12 products, pixel masks) and NEU-DET [10] (6 classes of steel-surface defect). NEU-DET has no defect-free class, so each class in turn is treated as normal: its support photos come from that class, and its test set is its 60 held-out images plus 60 taken evenly from the other five classes. NEU-DET has boxes but no masks, so we report image AUROC only. MPDD [7] has six metal parts (brackets, connectors, plates, tubes) photographed in varied positions, orientations and light, with pixel masks; it is the closest public benchmark to a shop floor that we found, and we use it with B/16 only.

Splits and statistics. For each product we draw 1, 5 and 10 support photos, nested so that the smaller sets are contained in the larger ones, and keep the whole test set fixed. This is repeated for three seeds (42, 1, 2). The split files are in the repository. Two configurations are compared on identical (product, shots, seed) splits; we report the mean difference and how many paired standard errors (SE) it is, and treat a difference as real only above 2×SE. For the comparison with WinCLIP we also follow its protocol on MVTec AD: 1, 2 and 4 photos and five seeds (0–4), with split files of their own.

Baseline. PatchCore from anomalib (WideResNet-50-2, layers 2 and 3, nine neighbours for re-weighting) receives exactly our support photos, test images, masks and

Table 1: Image / pixel AUROC with the single-pass memory, mean over three seeds (NEU-DET: image only). Records: `benchmark` runs, paired tests in `*_backbones.json` and `*_l14_vs_b16.json`.

	backbone	1 photo	5 photos	10 photos
MVTec	B/32	.837/.920	.884/.934	.904/.940
	B/16	.856/.916	.888/.932	.904/.936
	L/14	.883/.930	.920/.942	.933/.945
VisA	B/32	.681/.905	.761/.930	.779/.935
	B/16	.773/.934	.811/.947	.831/.951
	L/14	.785/.950	.828/.961	.843/.964
NEU-DET	B/32	.818	.867	.893
	B/16	.821	.868	.887
	L/14	.838	.883	.897

metric code. We switch its coreset subsampling off, since a ten-photo memory is small and subsampling would only remove information.

Hardware. All timings come from one laptop with an Intel i7-13700H (6 performance and 8 efficiency cores), CPU only, batch size one, 6 threads, five warm-up passes and the median of 20. With 14 threads the same graph measured 36 ms and 526 ms in consecutive runs, because work landed on both core types; with six threads repeated runs agreed within 20%.

5 Results

The backbone should match the defect size. Table 1 shows the single-pass results. On MVTec AD and NEU-DET the cheap B/32 is as accurate as B/16: no difference reaches 2×SE (at ten photos, +0.000 on MVTec and −0.007 on NEU-DET). On VisA B/16 is better at every shot count, by 0.093, 0.050 and 0.052 (4.4–5.5×SE). The masks explain why. A VisA defect covers 0.04–0.9% of the image, an MVTec AD defect 4.6% on average, and a NEU-DET defect box 39%. A B/32 patch covers 2.0% of the image and a B/16 patch 0.5%. When a defect is smaller than a patch, its signal is diluted by the normal pixels around it. B/16's largest VisA gains are on its smallest-defect products. The practical rule is simple: estimate the smallest defect that matters, and pick the cheapest backbone whose patch is smaller than that. L/14 (0.4% per patch) is best on MVTec AD (+0.030 over B/16, 4.6×SE), mainly on fine defects (`toothbrush` +0.117, `screw` +0.086), but its gains on VisA and NEU-DET are not established, and it is 4.5 times slower.

More photos mainly reduce the luck of the draw. On MVTec AD with B/16, the standard deviation of image AUROC across seeds falls from 0.027 with one photo to 0.012 with ten, while the mean rises by 0.048. Results from a single draw of support photos, which many few-shot papers report, hide this spread.

Table 2: What each scoring choice adds, ViT-B/16, image AUROC. Windows $\{1, 2, 3\}$; text weight 0.5; ML = patch tokens from blocks 6, 9 and 12. Records: `text_fusion*.json`, `*_windowed.json`, `ml_*.json`, `neu_det_text.json`.

		good photos		
	scoring	1	5	10
MVTec	last block	.856	.888	.904
	+ windows	.866	.907	.921
	+ text	.872	.897	.911
	+ windows + text	.881	.913	.925
	ML	.898	.928	.938
	ML + windows	.892	.934	.945
VisA	last block	.773	.811	.831
	+ windows	.789	.832	.851
	+ windows + text	.815	.841	.855
	ML	.807	.857	.872
	ML + windows	.826	.868	.881
NEU-DET	last block	.821	.868	.887
	+ windows	.865	.917	.935
	+ windows + text	.825	.866	.881
	ML	.855	.887	.911
	ML + windows	.874	.906	.930
MPDD	last block	.721	.779	.808
	ML + windows	.690	.781	.824

Windows help everywhere; text only where "normal" is meaningful. Scoring windows of patches raises image AUROC by 0.017–0.019 on MVTec AD at five and ten photos (3.3–4.3×SE), by 0.016–0.021 on VisA (2.7–5.5×SE) and by 0.044–0.049 on NEU-DET (3.3–5.6×SE, every class), and needs no extra encoder pass. The text prompt helps most with one photo (+0.016 on MVTec AD, +0.018 on VisA, at least 3.9×SE). On NEU-DET it costs 0.040–0.054. That is what one should expect: there the normal class is itself a type of defect, so a prompt such as "a crazing with a defect" has no sensible meaning. Text alone, without the memory, scored 0.802 on MVTec AD and 0.698 on VisA.

Earlier blocks localise better. On the two object datasets, adding blocks 6 and 9 is the largest single gain in this study. On MVTec AD it raises image AUROC by 0.034–0.043 (3.5–5.8×SE) and pixel AUROC by 0.021–0.025 (7.7–7.9×SE); every product improves at five and ten photos, and every product localises better at every shot count. On VisA the gains are 0.034–0.046 image (3.8–5.3×SE) and 0.011 pixel AUROC (4.1–4.7×SE). Windows add a little on top (Table 2). The result does not hold everywhere. On NEU-DET the gain over the last block, 0.019–0.034, stays below 2×SE, and with win-

Table 3: PatchCore given exactly our support photos and test images, and the paired difference ours minus PatchCore at ten photos (multiple of SE in brackets). ML = blocks 6/9/12. Records: `patchcore_vs_*.json`.

	1 photo	5 photos	10 photos
PatchCore MVTec img/pix	.842/.938	.899/.958	.926/.965
PatchCore VisA img/pix	.793/.945	.848/.964	.865/.969
PatchCore MPDD img/pix	.569/.936	.705/.955	.758/.960
	MVTec img	VisA img	MVTec pix
ours B/16	−.022 (1.7)	−.034 (3.3)	−.029 (4.7)
ours B/16+win	−.005 (0.5)	−.015 (1.7)	−.027 (6.4)
ours L/14	+.007 (0.5)	−.022 (1.9)	−.020 (2.9)
ours B/16 ML+win	+.018 (2.1)	+.016 (2.2)	−.003 (0.6)

dows the multi-layer features are only level with windows alone. On MPDD the multi-layer features with windows are within 1.6×SE of the last block at every shot count. Slicing the cached MVTec AD features shows where the gain comes from (`layer_ablation_*.json`). Block 6 alone reaches 0.936 image and 0.963 pixel AUROC with ten photos, nearly all of the image gain and the best localisation of any setting we measured; block 9 alone reaches 0.926 and 0.948. We fixed the three blocks before this test, so we keep them rather than pick block 6 on test data. Once the features are richer the text prompt matters less: with one photo it adds 0.007 on MVTec AD and 0.015 on VisA (3.0–3.4×SE), and at five or ten photos at most 0.003, within noise (`text_fusion_ml6-9-12_win123.json`).

Against PatchCore. With last-block features and windows, our image AUROC is statistically level with PatchCore on MVTec AD and VisA (Table 3); L/14 is ahead with one photo on MVTec AD (+0.042, 2.0×SE). With the last block, PatchCore localises better by 0.02–0.03 pixel AUROC (3–6×SE): its feature map has 28×28 cells against B/16's 14×14. Multi-layer features change both comparisons. With them and windows, our image AUROC is above PatchCore's at one, five and ten photos on MVTec AD (+0.050, +0.035, +0.018; 2.1–3.2×SE), on VisA (+0.034, +0.020, +0.016; 2.2–2.5×SE) and on MPDD (+0.121, +0.076, +0.067; 2.4–2.8×SE), and the localisation gap on MVTec AD closes (at most 0.6×SE either way). PatchCore still localises VisA's very small defects better, by 0.008–0.010 at five and ten photos (2.8–3.7×SE), and MPDD's by 0.009 at ten (2.6×SE). Per product the two fail differently. Ours does better on fine, textured defects (`screw` +0.120, `grid` +0.087, VisA `capsules` +0.050), PatchCore where a defect is a correctly made component in the wrong place (`transistor` −0.173, VisA `pcb3` −0.115). Per image the cost is similar: PatchCore with ten photos runs at 93 ms and 0.6 GB, our B/16 at 88 ms and the multi-layer B/16 at 94–97 ms.

Table 4: INT8 against FP32: ten-photo image AUROC, ONNX latency (batch 1, 6 threads) and model size. Records: `int8_*.json`, `int8_latency.json`.

	MVTec	VisA	ms/img	MB
B/32 FP32	.904	.779	39–41	352
B/32 INT8	.891	.765	27–33	89
B/16 FP32	.904	.831	131–133	345
B/16 INT8	.885	.819	71–72	88

Against WinCLIP. WinCLIP reports few-shot results on MVTec AD with 1, 2 and 4 photos over five seeds. We repeated that protocol for our best configuration (multi-layer features, windows and text) and for PatchCore (`winclip_protocol_mvtec_ad.json`). Our PatchCore run scores 84.0, 87.1 and 89.1 image AUROC (×100), within 0.8 points of the 83.4, 86.3 and 88.8 that WinCLIP reports for PatchCore, so the two protocols agree. We score 89.4/94.5, 91.2/95.2 and 92.9/95.7 (image/pixel), ahead of PatchCore by 3.9–5.5 image points (3.9–4.2×SE) and level with it at pixel level. The published WinCLIP+ figures are 93.1/95.2, 94.4/96.0 and 95.2/96.2, so we are 2.3–3.7 image points and 0.5–0.8 pixel points behind. We did not re-run WinCLIP+. It uses a larger LAION-trained ViT-B/16+ at 240 pixels and encodes each window separately, which means many encoder passes per image against our one.

INT8. Dynamic quantisation makes the encoder four times smaller and B/32 1.3 times, B/16 1.8 times faster (Table 4). It costs 0.012–0.019 image AUROC. Which backbone loses more depends on the dataset, and in no case does quantisation change which backbone is the right choice.

5.1 Adding a product

We put twelve MVTec products into memory and then added the remaining three, chosen in advance as the alphabetically last (`transistor`, `wood`, `zipper`), from five or ten photos. For every seed and shot count the twelve existing products scored bit-identically before and after, compared with `torch.equal`, and each added product scored bit-identically to a memory built with all fifteen from the start. Adding a product took 2.0–2.3 s with five photos and 3.3–3.7 s with ten, almost all of it encoding the photos; storing them took under 2 ms. The application exercises the same property: re-inspecting a part after adding another product reports the identical score.

5.2 Cost

On a cool machine, one image takes 37 ms with B/32 (3.0 GFLOPs), 88 ms with B/16 (11.3) and 397 ms with L/14 (52.0). Searching the memory adds 0.3–2.9 ms, about 1%, so using ten photos instead of one is effectively free

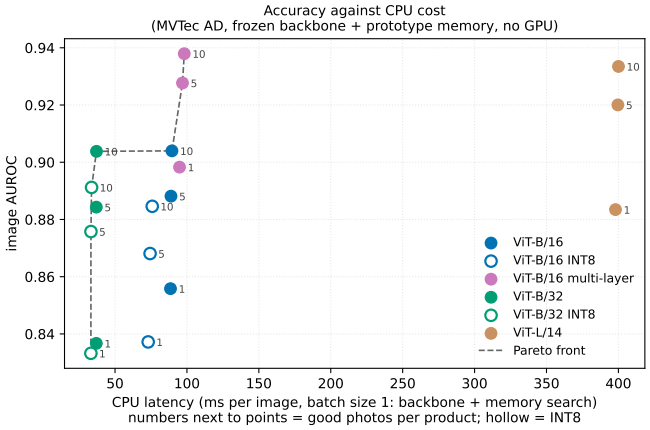


Figure 1: MVTec AD image AUROC against CPU time per image (encoder plus memory search), PyTorch FP32 (filled) and ONNX INT8 (hollow); numbers are photos per product. Multi-layer points are without windows. Dashed: Pareto front. Record: `figures.json`.

(Fig. 1). The multi-layer B/16 takes 94–97 ms in two runs (`ml_latency.json`): the earlier blocks are computed in any case and are only kept, and the search over three-times-longer vectors takes 4.4–5.0 ms with ten photos. Its five- and ten-photo points lie on the Pareto front, more accurate than L/14 at a quarter of its time. The inspector needs 1.5 GB of RAM in PyTorch with B/32 or B/16, 3.7 GB with L/14, and 0.38 GB for the INT8 ONNX encoder. Under continuous use the picture changes. B/32 held 40 ms for four minutes; then the CPU clock dropped and it settled at about 230 ms, 5.8 times slower. B/16 and L/14, measured on the already warm machine, ran at 630–680 ms and about 2 s. Capacity should be planned on these figures. Even so, at 10,000 parts a day the laptop is busy for at most 1.8 hours with B/16 (5.6 with L/14). At 45 W and Rs 8 per kWh this costs Rs 9.80 a year with B/32 INT8 and Rs 26 with B/16; the hardware already exists. All benchmarks in this study used at least 6.8 CPU-hours and no GPU.

5.3 Verification

Re-extracting every feature from the raw images reproduced all 135 MVTec AD (B/16) and 108 VisA (B/32) result rows to within 0.0002. On the second author's laptop, a fresh install from the pinned requirements passed all tests and reproduced the MVTec AD and VisA tables to three decimals; NEU-DET, produced on that laptop, was reproduced on the first author's machine to within 0.0005, and its split files regenerated byte-identically. The Colab notebook reproduces one product's results exactly. For the multi-layer encoder, a unit test checks that asking for block 12 alone returns the original features, and block 12 sliced out of the cached multi-layer MVTec AD features matched the original features with cosine similarity 1.0.

6 Discussion

What a workshop should do. Photograph ten good parts rather than one: the extra photos cost nothing at inference and halve the run-to-run spread. Use B/32, or its INT8 version, if the defects that matter are larger than about 2% of the photo; otherwise use B/16 with multi-layer features and windows, checking on a few known defects that the multi-layer features help on that product, since on NEU-DET and MPDD they did not. Add a defect description only when the product has a clear notion of normal. Expect a laptop to run several times slower than its first-minute speed once it has warmed up.

Threats to validity. The benchmarks are photographed under controlled light, so they say little about a shop floor; MPDD is closer, but still a curated set. Our main tables use three seeds, fewer than WinCLIP's five; only the WinCLIP comparison uses five. We fixed the blocks in advance, but we decided to try multi-layer features after seeing PatchCore's lead in localisation, and they helped on two of the four datasets. The NEU-DET protocol is our own. All timings come from one laptop model; a different cooling design will throttle differently. The suggested threshold is a heuristic: in the application it rejected 9 of 20 good bottles with five photos, and with three photos of `metal_nut` it missed every defect.

7 Limitations and future work

Defects thinner than a patch remain hard (`screw` reaches 0.792 with L/14). We compared with WinCLIP+'s published numbers rather than re-running it, did not run AnomalyCLIP, did not export the multi-layer encoder to INT8 or test static INT8, and did not collect photographs from a real workshop; the last is the most important next step. A calibrated threshold, for example one that fixes the expected false-reject rate, would make the application safer to use unattended.

8 Conclusion

A frozen CLIP encoder and a per-product memory of good patches can inspect parts from ten photographs on an ordinary laptop. With patch tokens from three of the encoder's blocks, its detection is better than PatchCore's given the same photos on all three datasets where we ran PatchCore, its localisation is level on MVTec AD, and a new product can be added in seconds without changing anything about the others. The cost results matter as much as the accuracies: choose the backbone by defect size, and plan on the throttled speed.

Use of AI tools

An AI assistant (Claude, Anthropic) was used during this project to help write code, run and organise experiments, and draft and edit text, including this paper. All experiments were run on our hardware, every number was checked against the result files in the repository, and the authors take responsibility for the content.

Reproducibility. Code, split files, result records and one command per table (`python scripts/reproduce.py --list`): `https://github.com/Mounika-Reddy-0802/fewshot-msme-inspect`.

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